07-28 第1篇

阅读理解（说明文） Why Do We Yawn — and Is It Really Catching?

① Every classroom in the world shares one small, quiet drama. A teacher writes on the board, a student in the back row stretches his mouth into a big, slow "aah", and within seconds three or four other students open their mouths too. The teacher turns around, already yawning herself, a little surprised. We have all seen this. We have all done it. But few of us have ever stopped to ask: **what exactly is a yawn, and why does one yawn seem to travel so easily from person to person?**

② A yawn is, on the outside, a simple action: we open the mouth wide, take a long deep breath in, hold it for a moment, and then let it out. But inside, quite a lot is happening. The deep breath pulls extra air into our lungs. At the same time, the jaw stretches, and the small muscles around the face and neck are pulled and released. Many scientists believe the most common reason for yawning is not what most people think — not a lack of oxygen in the blood. In fact, several careful experiments have shown that giving a person pure oxygen does **not** stop yawning.

③ So why do we yawn? One strong idea, suggested by researchers at Princeton University, is that yawning helps **cool the brain**. When we are tired, sitting in a warm, quiet room for a long time, our brain's temperature rises slightly. A big yawn pulls a rush of cooler air into the back of the throat; the stretching of jaw muscles also pushes warmer blood out of the head. Studies in which people held a cold pack to their forehead found a clear result: yawning almost disappeared. In a way, a yawn may be the body's quiet way of switching on a small "fan" to help the brain stay alert.

④ This also helps explain when we yawn. Most people yawn more when they are sleepy, bored, or about to start something new — a moment when the brain may need a tiny push. Athletes have been seen yawning before a big race; pilots yawn before landing; many students yawn before a hard exam. The yawn is not a sign of giving up; it may be a small wake-up call from the body to itself.

⑤ Now, the second question. When a classmate yawns, why do we want to yawn too? Scientists call this **contagious yawning**. Research has shown that humans over the age of four are much more likely to yawn right after seeing, hearing, or even reading about someone else yawning. (If you are already yawning as you read this paragraph, the research is probably right.) Very young children and most animals — except dogs, chimps, and a few others — do not usually catch yawns from others.

⑥ What is the reason? Experts do not yet have a complete answer, but the most common idea is linked to **empathy** — our ability to feel with others. Our brains have a group of cells called **mirror neurons**, which fire both when we do something ourselves and when we see someone else do it. When we see a yawn, the same brain area wakes up as if we were yawning. Interestingly, studies show that we are more likely to catch yawns from people we know well — family, close friends — than from strangers. A yawn, in this sense, is a small, unspoken way of saying "I notice you".

⑦ A yawn has another quiet job, too: it helps **open our ears**. When the air pressure around us changes quickly — for example, when a plane takes off, or when a bus enters a long tunnel — the pressure inside our ears may not match the pressure outside, and the ears feel stuffed. A wide yawn opens a small tube between the throat and the middle ear, and the pressure quickly balances. That is why, when our ears feel full, a simple yawn often brings instant relief.

⑧ So the next time a yawn slips out of your mouth in class, do not feel guilty. Your brain may be cooling itself, your body may be getting ready for a difficult task, or your quiet mirror neurons may have just noticed a tired friend across the aisle. A yawn is not a crime of laziness. It is one of the body's small, clever tools — and, in its own shy way, also a quiet sign of human connection.

根据文章内容，选择最佳答案。

1. According to the passage, what is NOT a likely reason for yawning?

A. The brain needs to cool down.
B. The body prepares for a new task.
C. The blood has too little oxygen.
D. The mirror neurons notice someone else yawning.

2. What did the Princeton experiments suggest about yawning?

A. Yawning is caused by cold air only.
B. Yawning may help cool the brain; when people held a cold pack to the forehead, yawning almost disappeared.
C. Yawning is caused by mobile phones.
D. Yawning is a disease that spreads in classrooms.

3. Who, according to paragraph ⑤, rarely "catches" yawns from others?

A. Middle-school students.
B. Pilots during landing.
C. Very young children and most animals (except dogs, chimps and a few others).
D. Tired university students.

4. Why can a yawn help open our ears on a plane?

A. Because it scares the air outside.
B. Because it opens a small tube between the throat and the middle ear, balancing the pressure inside and outside the ear.
C. Because it makes the ear larger.
D. Because it heats the eardrum.

5. What is the main message of the last paragraph?

A. A yawn is always a sign of laziness.
B. A yawn is a useful tool of the body and a quiet sign of human connection; we should not feel guilty about it.
C. Students should try never to yawn again.
D. Yawning should be banned in classrooms.

答案与解析

1.
【答案】C
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第②段 "giving a person pure oxygen does not stop yawning."
【解析】缺氧并非主因。A/B/D 均为文中可能原因。故选 C。

2.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第③段 "cold pack to their forehead... yawning almost disappeared."
【解析】降温抑制打哈欠。A/C/D 均错。故选 B。

3.
【答案】C
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第⑤段 "Very young children and most animals..."
【解析】幼儿与多数动物不传染。A/B/D 均易传染。故选 C。

4.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第⑦段 "opens a small tube between the throat and the middle ear..."
【解析】打开咽鼓管平衡气压。A/C/D 均错。故选 B。

5.
【答案】B
【题型】主旨大意题

【定位】第⑧段
【解析】哈欠是身体工具与人际信号，不必自责。A/C/D 均偏。故选 B。

词汇注释（超纲词）

- **jaw** [n.] 下巴
- **oxygen** [n.] 氧气
- **contagious** [adj.] 有传染性的
- **empathy** [n.] 共情
- **neuron** [n.] 神经元